

Fictora Content Producer Setup

Fictora episode production — setup handout for content producers

Repository: <https://github.com/DreamFlux-Workspace/fictora-content-creation>

Audience: Content producers (e.g. Mihir, Tejas) using Cursor with the episode-production skill

Updated: September 2026

Day-to-day operations: [docs/content-ops/Content-Operator-Guide.md](#) (gates, commands, local captions).

1. What this is

You produce short **9:16 vertical episodes** (~15 seconds) using:

- This **GitHub repo** (tools + agent instructions only)
- **Cursor** (AI agent runs production steps)
- The hosted **Drama Generation API** (drawing, boards, filming, post on Fictora servers)

You do **not** need the private fictora-drama repository. Your review surface is a **desk folder** on your Mac (~/Downloads/documents/...) with plates/, boards/, and takes/.

You **approve** faces, script lines, and storyboards **before** the ~\$1.20 take is filmed.

2. What you need from DreamFlux / engineering

Item	Notes
GitHub access	Clone DreamFlux-Workspace/fictora-content-creation
API service token	See Section 3 — required in .env
Cursor (recommended)	Open the cloned repo as the workspace

Item	Notes
macOS	Tested workflow; Linux likely works with uv

Security: Never paste the API token into Cursor chat, Slack, or email. Never commit the `.env` file.

3. Environment variables (required setup)

Create a file named `.env` in the repo root (copy from `.env.example`).

Required

Variable	Description
<code>FICTORA_DRAMA_GENERATION_SERVICE_TOKEN</code>	Bearer token for all <code>/v1/</code> API calls. Required. Ask engineering if you do not have it.

Optional

Variable	If unset
<code>FICTORA_DRAMA_GENERATION_API_BASE_URL</code>	Defaults to production: <code>https://fictora-drama-generation-prod-drama.up.railway.app</code>
<code>FICTORA_DRAMA_GENERATION_SESSION_ID</code>	Each desk stores its own session in <code>production.json</code> after you run <code>start</code> — you usually leave this commented out

Minimal `.env` example

```
FICTORA_DRAMA_GENERATION_API_BASE_URL=https://fictora-drama-generation-prod-drama.up.railway.app
FICTORA_DRAMA_GENERATION_SERVICE_TOKEN=paste-your-token-here
```

Desk files (not environment variables)

After you start a series, the agent uses files on your desk:

File	Purpose
<code><desk>/production.json</code>	Current phase, spine id, session id
<code><desk>/production.config.json</code>	Clip length (15s), captions (house), draft episode count (4)

4. One-time machine setup (~10 minutes)

1. **Install uv** (Python tool runner): <https://docs.astral.sh/uv/>

2. **Clone the repo:**

```
git clone https://github.com/DreamFlux-Workspace/fictora-content-creation.git
cd fictora-content-creation
```

3. **Configure credentials:**

```
cp .env.example .env
```

Open `.env` in a text editor and set `FICTORA_DRAMA_GENERATION_SERVICE_TOKEN`.

4. **Install project dependencies:**

```
uv sync
```

5. **Open the repo folder in Cursor.** The included **episode-production** skill tells the agent how to run production safely (human gates, one paid step per turn).

6. **Verify read-only API access (optional):**

```
uv run python scripts/smoke_live.py --phase read
```

This checks presets and desk tooling without spending on LLM/video.

5. Production flow (your role vs the agent)

start → [YOU: aligned] → draft → cast plates → [YOU: plates ok] → script → [YOU: script ok]
→ storyboard → [YOU: board ok] → estimate → [YOU: yes] → raw take
→ local house captions → [YOU: review captioned MP4]

Default: **no --api-captions** — filming stops at the **raw** clip; yellow subtitles are burned on your Mac (see [Content-Operator-Guide.md](#)).

Step	You open	You say
Plates	ep01/plates/	“plates ok” or what is wrong
Script	lines in chat / scripts/	“script ok” or revised lines
Board	ep01/boards/	“board ok” (or accept dim board if agent warns)
Cost	number in chat	“yes” to spend, or stop
Take	ep01/takes/	use it, or ask for a fix with a clear cause

Silence is not approval. Each episode needs fresh yeses at each gate.

Starting a new series (paste to Cursor)

Use the full template in [Content-Operator-Guide.md](#) (includes --draft-episodes 4, --cut-tempo one_shot, local captions). Short form:

Read episode-production SKILL.md. fictora-produce start for “[Series Name]”, 15s, modern-dark-fantasy, minimax-h3, premise: [your prompt]. One step per turn; wait for my aligned / yes at gates.

6. Desk folder layout

my-series-2026-09-22/

production.jsonproduction.config.jsonep01/

brief.mdplates/← approve facesscripts/boards/← approve storyboardtakes/← finished videoapi/← JSON logs (debugging)run-notes.md

7. Useful commands (agent usually runs these)

Action	Command
Start desk	uv run fictora-produce start --series "." --prompt "." --band 15s
Next API step	uv run fictora-produce step --desk <desk-path>
Approve gate	uv run fictora-produce approve --desk <path> --gate plates (or script, board)
Approve dim board	add --accept-dim to board approve
Confirm spend + film	uv run fictora-produce step --desk <path> --confirm-spend
Status	uv run fictora-produce status --desk <path>

8. Captions and audio

- Subtitles are **not** in the model output. Default path: **local burn** after the raw take (`api_captions: false`).
 - Review **take-ep01-t1-captioned-v*.mp4**, not only the raw file. Agent runs `scripts/burn_house_captions.sh` (needs `ffmpeg-full` + `libass`).
 - Captions appear only around the spoken line—scrub to that beat. Style: yellow #F5D547, black edge, no box ([local-captions.md](#)).
-

9. When something goes wrong

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
“Error reading body from connection”	Network blip while polling	Run step again on the same desk ; job often still running server-side
Stuck at 50% on video poll	Server post-prod tail	With local captions, harness should finish at raw clip (<code>17_raw_scene_clips.json</code>); ask agent to check job / re-step
503 <code>restate_unavailable</code>	Server orchestration down	Retry later; contact engineering
No file in takes/	Poll stopped early or delivery not fetched	Re-run step on same desk (resume without double-charging if enrol already saved)

10. Rules of the road

- Do **not** clone `fictora-drama`.
 - Do **not** approve plates, script, and board without opening the files.
 - Do **not** share your token or commit `.env`.
 - Do **not** film twice in parallel on the same desk without engineering guidance.
-

11. More documentation (in the repo)

- [docs/content-ops/Content-Operator-Guide.md](#) — **primary ops doc** (Mihir / Tejas)
 - `README.md` — technical overview
 - `docs/Episode-Production-Partner-Guide.md` — expanded partner guide
 - `docs/content-ops/runbook.md` — full production craft runbook
 - `docs/content-ops/examples/tram-not-tonight-ep1.md` — prod-validated ep1 example
 - `.cursor/skills/episode-production/SKILL.md` — agent instructions
-

12. Support

- **Token, outages, billing:** DreamFlux / Fictora engineering contact
- **Day-to-day production:** Cursor + this repo + human gates in Section 5